

The Edge Cases of Artificial Intelligence

A Plural-Epistemic Framework for AI Wisdom

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Overview

This framework identifies six civilizational edge cases in AI: failure modes that escape benchmarks because they feel like success. They emerge not from model malfunction, but from the epistemic, cultural, moral, and temporal blind spots embedded in the systems, and the cultures that build them.

The Six Edge Cases

1. **Epistemic Monoculture:** When a single way of knowing crowds out all others
2. **Meaning Collapse Under Optimization:** Systems optimize outputs while eroding meaning
3. **Alignment Without Wisdom:** The most dangerous failure mode feels like success
4. **Temporal Blindness:** Rational behavior applied in moments that require restraint
5. **Disappearance of the Questioner:** When AI becomes the sense-making layer, humans stop asking
6. **The Humility Gap:** Capability scales faster than the culture that holds it

Origin

This framework emerged from 13 years of direct work inside AI systems: building human-in-the-loop pipelines, governing trust and safety annotation programs, designing bias-resistant algorithms, and protecting the humans whose labor trains the models the world increasingly depends on.

Status

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Feedback, pushback, and extension are welcome.

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